AQA GCSE Geography (8035) — Paper 3: Geographical Applications · 3.3 Geographical Applications and 3.4 Geographical Skills

3.1 Issue Evaluation and Fieldwork

1. What Is Paper 3?

AQA **Paper 3: Geographical Applications** is a 1 hour 15 minute exam worth **76 marks** (including 6 marks for spelling, punctuation, grammar and specialist terminology) — 30% of the GCSE. It has two sections:

Section	What it tests	Marks
Section A — Issue evaluation	A critical thinking and problem-solving task based on a **pre-release resource booklet**, issued 12 weeks before the exam. You analyse the issue and make a justified decision.	37 (including 3 SPaG)
Section B — Fieldwork	Questions on fieldwork in general (unfamiliar contexts) and on your own two fieldwork enquiries.	39 (including 3 SPaG)

2. Issue Evaluation (Section A)

- The pre-release booklet introduces a geographical issue linked to the content of Papers 1 and 2 — past examples include Hornsea offshore wind farm, development in Malawi, a new rail link and flood defences.
- Questions build up from interpreting resources (maps, graphs, photographs, data) to a final **9-mark extended question** (plus 3 SPaG marks) where you choose and justify an option.

How to prepare

1. Read the booklet carefully and annotate every figure — what does it show, and how does it link to the issue?

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2. Make sure you understand any key terms and the place's location (use an atlas).
3. Identify the **stakeholders** (people affected) and their likely views.
4. Link the issue to topics you have studied (e.g. sustainability, development, hazards, resources).
5. Practise the decision question: consider economic, social and environmental impacts, short and long term, for each option.

Exam Tip — the 9-mark decision: There is no "right" option. Marks come from *justifying* your choice using evidence from the resources, explaining why it is better than the alternatives, and acknowledging its disadvantages and how they could be reduced. Refer to figure numbers ("Figure 4 shows...").

3. Fieldwork Requirements

- You must carry out **two geographical enquiries** in contrasting environments: one **physical** and one **human**, and at least one must show the interaction between physical and human geography.
- Each enquiry follows the six stages of the enquiry process below.
- Common physical enquiries: how a river's characteristics change downstream; how coastal management affects beach profiles; microclimate. Common human enquiries: urban regeneration, quality of life across a city, land use in a town centre, the impact of tourism.

4. The Six Stages of a Geographical Enquiry

Stage	What you need to know
1. Suitable question	Formulate an enquiry question or hypothesis that can be investigated through fieldwork. Know the geographical theory or concept behind it (e.g. the Bradshaw model for rivers) and why the location was suitable (safe, accessible, shows the feature being studied).

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2. Selecting, measuring and recording data	Primary data (collected yourself) and secondary data (collected by others, e.g. census data, Environment Agency flood data, maps). Sampling methods: **random**, **systematic** (at regular intervals) and **stratified** (in proportion to sub-groups). Know the equipment used and how to reduce risks.
3. Processing and presenting data	Choose suitable methods — line graphs, bar charts, pie charts, scatter graphs, cross-sections, choropleth maps, annotated photographs, flow-line maps. Justify why each was appropriate.
4. Describing, analysing and explaining	Describe patterns and trends, identify anomalies, use statistics (mean, median, mode, range, interquartile range) and explain the results using geographical theory.
5. Reaching conclusions	Answer the original question or say whether the hypothesis was proved, supported by evidence.
6. Evaluation	Identify problems with data collection (accuracy, reliability, sample size, weather, human error), limitations of the methods and conclusions, and suggest improvements and extensions.

5. Example Physical Enquiry: River Characteristics Downstream

Hypothesis: "Channel width, depth and velocity increase with distance downstream."

- **Theory:** the **Bradshaw model** predicts that width, depth, discharge and velocity increase downstream, while gradient and load particle size decrease.
- **Method:** systematic sampling at several sites along the river. Width measured with a tape measure; depth with a metre rule at regular intervals across the channel; velocity by timing a float over 10 m (repeated three times and averaged); pebble size with a ruler or callipers (10 pebbles per site, chosen randomly).
- **Presentation:** cross-sections for each site; scatter graphs of distance downstream against width, depth and velocity, with a line of best fit.
- **Risks:** drowning, slipping, cold water, waterborne disease (Weil's disease) — reduced by wearing wellingtons, working in groups, avoiding high-flow conditions and washing hands.

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- **Evaluation:** only a few sites were sampled; a single visit means results reflect that day's flow; floats can get stuck; human error reading measurements. Improvements: more sites, using a flow meter, repeating on several dates.

6. Example Human Enquiry: Quality of Life Across a City

Question: "How and why does the quality of the environment vary from the inner city to the suburbs?"

- **Theory:** urban land-use models (e.g. the Burgess concentric zone model) and the idea of inequality within cities.
- **Method:** a transect from the city centre outwards with systematic sampling every 500 m. At each site: an environmental quality survey (bipolar scoring of litter, graffiti, green space, building condition), pedestrian or traffic counts, noise readings, questionnaires using random or stratified sampling. Secondary data: Index of Multiple Deprivation, census data and house prices.
- **Presentation:** line graphs of score against distance; choropleth maps of deprivation; radar charts comparing sites; annotated photographs.
- **Evaluation:** environmental quality surveys are subjective (different students score differently); a small number of questionnaires may not be representative; time of day affects pedestrian counts. Improvements: group scoring with agreed criteria, larger samples and repeat visits.

7. Geographical Skills

Skills can be tested in all three papers. Make sure you can:

- **Cartographic:** use four- and six-figure grid references, scale and distance, compass directions, contour lines and spot heights on OS maps; describe and explain patterns on atlas and choropleth maps; interpret cross-sections and transects.
- **Graphical:** construct and interpret line graphs, bar charts, pie charts, scatter graphs (with lines of best fit), population pyramids, climate graphs, triangular graphs and dispersion diagrams.

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- **Numerical and statistical:** calculate percentages, percentage change, mean, median, mode, range, quartiles and interquartile range; understand correlation and the difference between correlation and causation.
- **Formulating enquiry:** identify questions, sequence investigations and evaluate sources.
- **Literacy:** write extended answers using specialist terms accurately — SPaG marks are awarded on selected questions in every paper.

Exam Tip: In fieldwork questions on your own enquiry, always name your location and give specific details (e.g. "we measured at 6 sites along Carding Mill Valley, 200 m apart"). Generic answers that could apply to anyone's fieldwork are capped at the lower levels.

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